

PSY405 - Lesson 41

Perspectives (Domains) of Personality Psychology

First: what is a “perspective” or “domain” in psychology?

A **perspective** (also called a **domain**) is simply a **lens** or **angle** from which psychologists study personality.

Think of personality like a **diamond** 

If you look at it from only one side, you miss a lot.

So psychologists said:

👉 “Let’s study personality from multiple angles.”

That’s why we have **six perspectives**.

The Six Perspectives (Big Picture First)

Personality can be studied using **six domains**:

1. **Dispositional**
2. **Biological**
3. **Intrapsychic (Psychodynamic)**
4. **Cognitive / Experiential**
5. **Social and Cultural**
6. **Adjustment**

Each one answers a **different question** about personality.

Quick Overview (So You Don’t Get Lost)

Perspective	Main Question
Dispositional	<i>What traits do people have?</i>
Biological	<i>How does biology shape personality?</i>

Perspective	Main Question
Intrapsychic	<i>How do unconscious conflicts shape us?</i>
Cognitive/Experiential	<i>How do thoughts and feelings shape personality?</i>
Social & Cultural	<i>How does society and culture shape us?</i>
Adjustment	<i>How does personality affect coping and health?</i>

Now let's **deep-dive** into the first **three**, because that's where your lesson focuses.

1. DISPOSITIONAL PERSPECTIVE

(aka **Trait Approach**)

Core Idea (Plain English)

People differ from each other because they have **different traits**.

Some people are:

- Calm
- Aggressive
- Shy
- Confident
- Organized
- Emotional

These **stable patterns** are called **traits**.

What does "dispositional" mean?

Disposition = an **inborn tendency** to behave in a certain way.

 Example:

- If someone is calm in most situations → calmness is their **disposition**
 - If someone gets angry quickly → irritability is their **disposition**
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Key Assumptions of the Dispositional Perspective

1. **People differ from each other**
 2. These differences are **relatively stable**
 3. Traits guide behavior across situations
 4. Traits can be **measured**
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Why does it “cut across all other domains”?

Because traits show up:

- In emotions (emotional vs stable)
- In biology (genetics, nervous system)
- In unconscious processes
- In social behavior

Traits are everywhere. They’re like the **operating system** of personality.

Traits (Very Important Concept)

What is a Trait?

Academic definition (translated):

A **trait** is a **stable mental structure** that explains why a person behaves consistently across time and situations.

Human version:

A trait is a **personality habit** that sticks.

📌 Example:

- If someone is honest at home, work, and with friends → honesty is a trait.
-

Traits = Raw Material of Personality

Personality is not random.

It’s built from **traits**, like a building is built from bricks 🧱

Big Questions in the Dispositional Approach

1. How many traits exist?

2. What is the best way to classify traits?

Psychologists didn't agree, so they created **three strategies**.

Three Approaches to Identifying Traits

1. Language Approach

Idea:

If a trait is important, people will create a word for it.

 Example:

- Shy
- Honest
- Aggressive
- Kind

Psychologists analyze dictionaries and everyday language.

2. Statistical Approach

This uses **math** (don't panic).

Key term: Factor Analysis

 A statistical method that finds patterns in behavior.

 Example:

If many behaviors cluster together (talkative, outgoing, energetic), they might form **one trait** → Extraversion.

3. Theoretical Approach

Traits are identified based on **theories** about personality.

👉 In real research, psychologists mix all three approaches.

Measuring Traits

Traits can be measured:

- **Qualitatively** (interviews, observations)
- **Quantitatively** (tests, questionnaires)

Good tests must be:

- **Standardized** (same rules for everyone)
- **Objective** (no bias)
- **Reliable** (consistent results)
- **Valid** (measures what it claims)
- **Hard to fake**

📌 Example:

Cattell's 16 Personality Factors (16PF)

Why Traits Matter Practically

Traits help in:

- Career selection
- Education
- Mental health

📌 Example:

- Aggressive person → maybe not ideal for daycare
 - Kind, patient person → good nurse
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Key Trait Theorists

Gordon Allport

Core Idea

Traits are the basic unit of personality.

Types of Traits (Allport)

1. Cardinal Traits

- Very dominant
- Shape entire personality
- Rare
- Example: Mother Teresa → compassion

2. Central Traits

- Main characteristics (5–10)
- Example: honest, anxious, friendly

3. Secondary Traits

- Situational
 - Less consistent
 - Example: nervous before exams only
-

Proprium (Allport)

Proprium = the self

It includes:

- Self-image
- Self-esteem
- Personal goals
- Values

Basically: **who you think you are**

Raymond Cattell

Core Tool: Factor Analysis

He believed traits are discovered, not guessed.

Types of Traits (Cattell)

1. Unique Traits

- Only in one person

2. Common Traits

- Shared by many

3. Surface Traits

- Observable behaviors

4. Source Traits

- Underlying causes
 - More important
-

Henry Murray – Needs & Motivation

What is a Need?

Academic definition (simplified):

A **need** is an internal force that drives behavior.

 Example:

- Need for achievement
 - Need for affiliation
 - Need for power
-

Types of Needs

1. Primary vs Secondary

- Primary: biological (food)
- Secondary: psychological (love)

2. Overt vs Covert

- Overt: visible
- Covert: hidden

3. Focal vs Diffuse

- Focal: specific goal
 - Diffuse: general tendency
-

TAT (Thematic Apperception Test)

Projective Test = ambiguous stimulus → person projects inner needs

 Example:

Show a picture → ask "What's happening?"

Response reveals **unconscious motives**.

2. BIOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVE

Core Idea

Personality is rooted in **biology** 

Three Biological Areas

1. Genetics

Behavior Genetics asks:

- Are twins similar?
- What happens if twins are raised apart?

📌 Identical twins → more similar personalities than fraternal twins.

2. Psychophysiology

Studies:

- Nervous system
- Hormones
- Neurotransmitters
- Heart rate
- Sleep patterns

📌 Example:

High arousal nervous system → anxiety-prone personality

3. Evolution

Traits exist because they helped humans **survive**.

📌 Example:

- Fear → survival
 - Cooperation → group survival
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Research Methods

- Selective breeding (animals)
 - Family studies
 - Twin studies
 - Adoption studies
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Biological Theorists

Freud (Yes, again)

- Emphasis on **sex and aggression**

- Personality develops in **psychosexual stages**
 - Oral → Anal → Phallic → Genital
-

Sheldon's Somatotype Theory

Body type = personality

- Endomorph → relaxed
- Mesomorph → aggressive
- Ectomorph → shy

(⚠️ outdated but historically important)

Erik Erikson

- Biology matters
 - Culture matters too
 - Gender differences are shaped by society
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Karen Horney (Important Feminist Voice)

- Rejected "anatomy is destiny"
 - Men ≠ superior
 - Emphasized **security and relationships**
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3. INTRAPSYCHIC (PSYCHODYNAMIC) PERSPECTIVE

Core Idea

Personality is shaped by **unconscious conflicts**.

Freud's Levels of Consciousness

1. **Conscious** – what you know now
 2. **Preconscious** – easily retrievable
 3. **Unconscious** – hidden, powerful
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Freud's Personality Structures

Id

- Primitive
- Pleasure principle
- "I want it NOW"

Ego

- Rational
- Reality principle
- "How can I get this safely?"

Superego

- Moral
 - Conscience
 - "This is right / wrong"
-

Anxiety Types

1. Reality anxiety – real danger
 2. Neurotic anxiety – fear of losing control
 3. Moral anxiety – guilt
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Defense Mechanisms

Unconscious coping strategies:

- Projection
 - Rationalization
 - Regression
 - Sublimation
 - Reaction formation
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Jung's Contributions

Personal Unconscious

Forgotten or repressed memories

Collective Unconscious

Inherited human memories

Archetypes

- Persona (mask)
 - Shadow (dark side)
 - Anima / Animus
 - Self (integration)
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Karen Horney (Again)

- Child-parent relationship is crucial
- Lack of security → **basic anxiety**
- Leads to **neurosis**
- Hostility is often unconscious

Short Question Answers

1. What is the dispositional perspective of personality?

Answer:

The dispositional perspective focuses on the ways individuals differ from one another. It studies **stable internal characteristics or traits** that guide behavior, emotions, and thoughts across situations. Traits are seen as the **building blocks of personality**, and psychologists aim to identify, classify, and measure them to understand individual differences.

Explanation:

Think of traits as **mental habits** that explain why a person behaves consistently. This perspective assumes that your personality is like a **set of tools in your toolbox**—everyone has a combination, but the mix is unique. These traits may be inherited but can also interact with the environment.

Example:

- Someone who is consistently friendly, curious, and organized has traits of **agreeableness, openness, and conscientiousness**.
- These traits make them likely to behave similarly at home, work, or school.

Tips:

- Remember “traits = building blocks of personality.”
 - Focus on **stable vs situational behavior**.
 - Key theorists: **Allport, Cattell, Murray**.
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2. What is a trait in personality psychology?

Answer:

A trait is a **stable mental characteristic** that influences how a person behaves across different situations. Traits are predispositions to respond consistently to certain types of stimuli. They are considered **internal structures** that organize thoughts, emotions, and actions.

Explanation:

Traits explain patterns in behavior. Instead of seeing actions as random, psychologists see traits as the **hidden reasons** behind consistent behaviors.

Example:

- Being honest across school, work, and family life is a trait of **honesty**.
- Being easily anxious in multiple settings indicates a trait of **neuroticism**.

Tips:

- Traits are **internal and stable**, not just situational moods.
 - Always link traits to observable behaviors for examples.
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3. What are the types of traits according to Allport?

Answer:

Allport classified traits into three types:

1. **Cardinal Traits:** Dominant traits that define a person's life. Rare.
2. **Central Traits:** Main characteristics that form the core of personality. Usually 5–10 traits.
3. **Secondary Traits:** Traits that appear only in specific situations.

Explanation:

Allport wanted to show that traits differ in **importance and pervasiveness**. Cardinal traits are so strong they dominate behavior, central traits are major but not overwhelming, and secondary traits are minor quirks or situational behaviors.

Example:

- **Cardinal:** Mother Teresa → compassion dominates her life.
- **Central:** Friendly, honest, anxious → core personality.
- **Secondary:** Nervous before exams → situational behavior.

Tips:

- Remember the scale: Cardinal > Central > Secondary (importance).

- Cardinal traits are **rare**, central traits are **common**, secondary traits are **situational**.
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4. How are traits measured?

Answer:

Traits are measured **qualitatively** (interviews, observations) and **quantitatively** (psychological tests and questionnaires). Modern measurement requires **reliability** (consistent results), **validity** (measuring what it claims), and **standardization** (applies equally to everyone).

Explanation:

Psychologists need reliable tools to make sure traits are accurately assessed. **Objective tests** reduce bias, and **projective tests** (like TAT) reveal unconscious motives.

Example:

- **Cattell's 16PF (16 Personality Factors)** test measures multiple traits.
- **TAT (Thematic Apperception Test)**: Show pictures and ask someone to tell a story; their responses reveal needs and motives.

Tips:

- Qualitative = descriptive; Quantitative = numerical/scientific.
 - Think **objective + reliable + valid = trusted measurement**.
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5. What is the biological perspective of personality?

Answer:

The biological perspective emphasizes that personality is influenced by **genetic, physiological, and evolutionary factors**. Humans are seen as **collections of biological systems**, and these systems shape behavior, thoughts, and emotions.

Explanation:

Biology acts as the **hardware**; personality is the **software** running on it. Genes, neurotransmitters, hormones, brain structure, and evolution all influence why

people behave differently.

Example:

- Identical twins raised apart often show similar personality traits → evidence of genetics.
- Morning people vs night people → influenced by circadian rhythms (biological clock).

Tips:

- Remember the three key areas: **Genetics, Psychophysiology, Evolution.**
 - Think of biology as the foundation that interacts with environment and culture.
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6. What is psychophysiology in personality?

Answer:

Psychophysiology studies **how the nervous system, hormones, and bodily functions influence personality**. It looks at reactions such as heart rate, pain tolerance, neurotransmitters, and circadian rhythms.

Explanation:

Different bodies respond differently to stimuli. A highly reactive nervous system may lead to a personality that is anxious or sensitive; hormones like testosterone may influence aggression or dominance.

Example:

- People with faster heart rate reactivity may be more prone to stress.
- Higher cortisol → more stress response → neurotic traits.

Tips:

- Link traits to **physical systems**.
 - Remember: biology affects **behavior patterns**, not just physical health.
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7. What is the intrapsychic (psychodynamic) perspective of personality?

Answer:

The intrapsychic perspective emphasizes **unconscious conflicts** between basic instincts (like sex and aggression) and social demands, which shape personality. Most of these conflicts occur in the **unconscious mind**, affecting thoughts, emotions, and behavior.

Explanation:

Freud suggested personality develops as humans try to **balance their desires (id)** with **reality (ego)** and **morality (superego)**. Defense mechanisms protect the ego from anxiety caused by these conflicts.

Example:

- Repression → forgetting a traumatic event to reduce anxiety.
- Projection → blaming others for your own feelings (e.g., "They hate me" when really you are angry at them).

Tips:

- Think **conflict + unconscious motives = personality patterns**.
- Key theorists: **Freud, Jung, Adler, Karen Horney**.

8. What are Freud's three levels of consciousness?

Answer:

1. **Conscious:** Thoughts and feelings we are aware of.
2. **Preconscious:** Thoughts not currently in awareness but accessible.
3. **Unconscious:** Thoughts, memories, and desires we are unaware of but that influence behavior.

Explanation:

The unconscious is the **biggest influence**. We often act in ways we don't fully understand because of unconscious motives.

Example:

- You might feel anxious without knowing why → unconscious conflict.

- A dream revealing hidden fears → unconscious mind at work.

Tips:

- Remember: Conscious = tip of iceberg, Unconscious = massive hidden part.
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9. What are Freud's structural components of personality?

Answer:

1. **Id:** Primitive instincts, pleasure-driven.
2. **Ego:** Rational, reality-oriented, mediates between id and superego.
3. **Superego:** Moral conscience, develops last, reflects societal rules.

Explanation:

Id wants instant gratification, ego finds realistic ways, superego enforces moral rules. Personality is shaped by how these three interact.

Example:

- Id: Eat cake now.
- Ego: Eat a small piece, not the whole cake.
- Superego: Maybe I shouldn't eat any cake because it's unhealthy.

Tips:

- Id = "I want," Ego = "How can I get it safely?" Superego = "Should I do it?"
 - Conflicts among these structures explain anxiety and defense mechanisms.
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10. What are defense mechanisms? Give examples.

Answer:

Defense mechanisms are **unconscious strategies** the ego uses to protect itself from anxiety caused by id-superego conflicts.

Examples:

- **Repression:** Pushing unwanted thoughts into the unconscious.

- **Projection:** Attributing your feelings to someone else.
- **Sublimation:** Channeling impulses into socially acceptable actions.
- **Displacement:** Redirecting emotions to a safer target.

Explanation:

Defense mechanisms **reduce internal conflict**. They operate unconsciously but influence behavior.

Example:

- Anger at boss → yells at sibling instead (displacement).
- Sexual energy → becomes an artist (sublimation).

Tips:

- Always connect defense mechanisms to **ego protecting itself**.
 - Look for **subtle examples in daily life**.
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11. What are Jung's archetypes?

Answer:

Archetypes are **universal inherited symbols or patterns** in the collective unconscious. They guide human behavior and thought.

Main Archetypes:

- **Persona:** Social mask
- **Shadow:** Dark, hidden self
- **Anima / Animus:** Feminine in men / masculine in women
- **Self:** Integrated personality

Explanation:

Jung believed humans inherit a **psychological history**. Archetypes are templates for how we experience the world.

Example:

- Persona → act polite at work, wild at home.

- Shadow → hidden anger or jealousy we rarely show.

Tips:

- Collective unconscious = “shared human experience.”
- Archetypes = patterns repeated in myths, stories, dreams.

Long-Question Answers

1. What are the six perspectives of personality psychology, and how do they differ?

Answer:

Personality can be studied from **six major perspectives**, each focusing on different aspects of human behavior and personality:

Perspective	Focus	Key Question	Key Theorists/Concepts
Dispositional	Traits and individual differences	How do people differ from each other?	Allport, Cattell, Murray
Biological	Genetics, physiology, evolution	How do biological systems shape personality?	Freud, Sheldon, Erikson
Intrapsychic (Psychodynamic)	Unconscious conflicts, drives	How do unconscious conflicts shape behavior?	Freud, Jung, Adler, Horney
Cognitive / Experiential	Thoughts, beliefs, subjective experiences	How do cognition and experiences influence personality?	Kelly, Bandura
Social and Cultural	Society and culture	How does culture influence personality?	Hofstede, Triandis
Adjustment	Coping and adaptation	How does personality affect health, coping, and adjustment?	Lazarus, Carver

Explanation (Plain English):

Think of personality like a **diamond with multiple faces**. Looking at only one angle gives a partial picture. Each perspective asks a **different “why”** about human behavior:

- Dispositional → Why are people different?
- Biological → Why do our bodies and genes matter?
- Intrapsychic → What hidden conflicts shape us?
- Cognitive → How do thoughts and feelings influence personality?
- Social/Cultural → How do society and culture shape us?
- Adjustment → How do personality traits affect coping and health?

Example:

- A person may be **naturally anxious** (dispositional), **genetically prone to stress** (biological), feel **guilt unconsciously** (intrapsychic), interpret situations negatively (cognitive), live in a competitive culture (social/cultural), and struggle with sleep and diet as a result (adjustment).

Tip:

- Think of perspectives as **different lenses**, each highlighting a piece of personality.
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2. Explain the dispositional perspective and its major theories.

Answer:

A. Core Idea

- Focuses on **stable internal traits** that explain why people behave consistently.
- Traits are **building blocks of personality** and guide emotions, thoughts, and behavior.

B. Key Concepts

1. **Trait:** A stable mental structure that accounts for consistency in behavior.

2. **Disposition:** Inborn tendencies to act a certain way; traits are dispositional.

3. **Types of Traits (Allport):**

- **Cardinal:** Dominant, rare, shapes entire life (e.g., Mother Teresa → compassion).
- **Central:** Core traits (5–10) forming personality (e.g., honesty, friendly, anxious).
- **Secondary:** Situational traits, minor quirks (e.g., nervous before exams).

4. **Proprium (Allport):** The "self," including values, goals, and personal identity.

C. Trait Identification Methods

Method	How it works	Example
Language Approach	Analyzing words used in daily life	"Honest," "curious," "shy"
Statistical Approach	Factor analysis to find clusters of traits	Extraversion cluster → talkative, sociable, energetic
Theoretical Approach	Based on psychological theory	Murray's needs → identify important traits like achievement

D. Measurement of Traits

- **Qualitative:** Observations, interviews
- **Quantitative:** Questionnaires, standardized tests (e.g., Cattell's 16PF)
- **Key Requirements:** Reliable, valid, standardized, objective

E. Major Theorists

- **Gordon Allport:** Traits, proprium, cardinal/central/secondary traits
- **Raymond Cattell:** Factor analysis, source vs surface traits
- **Henry Murray:** Needs, projective tests (TAT)

Example:

- A friendly, curious, organized person → high in openness, agreeableness, conscientiousness.

- Career implications: A highly conscientious person → suited for auditing; highly agreeable → suited for nursing.

Explanation (Plain English):

Dispositional perspective says **your personality is like your toolset**. Traits are the tools you carry: some are strong, some weak, some used often, some occasionally. Psychologists try to **identify, classify, and measure** these tools to understand behavior.

Tip:

- Remember: **Traits = building blocks, Proprium = the self, Methods = language + stats + theory.**

3. Explain the biological perspective and its application in personality psychology.

Answer:

A. Core Idea

Personality is influenced by **genetics, nervous system, hormones, and evolution**. Biology forms the **hardware** that enables personality **software** to run.

B. Three Main Biological Areas

1. Genetics

- Personality traits have hereditary components.
- Key method: Twin studies, family studies, adoption studies.
- Example: Identical twins raised apart → often show similar personalities.

2. Psychophysiology

- Examines bodily functions influencing personality: nervous system, neurotransmitters, heart rate, circadian rhythms, hormones.
- Example: Higher cortisol → more stress-prone; morning people vs night people.

3. Evolution

- Personality traits evolved to solve adaptive problems.
- Example: Fear → survival; cooperation → group survival.

C. Major Theorists and Applications

Theorist	Contribution
Freud	Biological basis of sex and aggression; psychosexual stages
Sheldon	Somatotype theory: body type → personality (endomorph, mesomorph, ectomorph)
Erikson	Biology + culture → personality development
Karen Horney	Rejected strict biological determinism; emphasized security

Example:

- Freud → Aggression as part of human instincts.
- Sheldon → Mesomorph (muscular) → assertive and dominant; Ectomorph → shy, introverted.

Explanation (Plain English):

Biology explains **why people might have different tendencies even if raised the same way**. Genes, body, and evolution are the **starting point** for personality, though environment and culture shape the rest.

Tip:

- Remember the “three Bs” of biological perspective: **Biology, Brain, Behavior**.

4. Explain the intrapsychic (psychodynamic) perspective.

Answer:

A. Core Idea

Personality is shaped by **unconscious conflicts** between basic instincts (id), societal rules (superego), and rational thought (ego).

Most conflicts occur at the **unconscious level**, influencing everyday behavior.

B. Freud's Key Concepts

1. Levels of Consciousness

- **Conscious:** Thoughts we are aware of.
- **Preconscious:** Thoughts easily accessible.
- **Unconscious:** Hidden memories and drives influencing behavior.

2. Personality Structures

- **Id:** Instincts, pleasure principle ("I want it now").
- **Ego:** Reality principle, mediates id and superego ("How can I get it safely?").
- **Superego:** Morality, societal rules ("Should I do it?").

3. Defense Mechanisms

- Strategies ego uses to reduce anxiety:
 - Repression, projection, displacement, sublimation, reaction formation.

4. Psychosexual Development

- Stages from birth → adulthood: Oral, Anal, Phallic, Latency, Genital
- Conflicts at each stage influence personality.

C. Jung's Contributions

- **Personal Unconscious:** Forgotten or repressed experiences
- **Collective Unconscious:** Shared human experiences, ancestral memory
- **Archetypes:** Persona, Shadow, Anima/Animus, Self

D. Karen Horney

- Emphasized **child-parent relationships**
- Basic anxiety → unconscious hostility → neurosis
- Rejected "anatomy is destiny"

Example:

- A person unconsciously fears abandonment → becomes clingy in relationships (intrapsychic influence).
- Dreams revealing hidden desires → reflect unconscious conflicts.

Explanation (Plain English):

The psychodynamic perspective says **what's in your unconscious is powerful**. Your mind isn't just conscious thinking—it's like an iceberg: most of your personality is underwater. Unresolved conflicts from childhood and instincts influence everything you do, often without awareness.

Tip:

- Remember **Id = wants, Ego = plans, Superego = morals**.
 - Jung = collective human memory; Horney = security matters more than biology.
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5. Explain the cognitive / experiential perspective.

Answer:**A. Core Idea**

Personality is shaped by **conscious thoughts, beliefs, feelings, and subjective experiences**.

Focuses on **how people perceive and interpret their experiences**.

B. Key Concepts

- **Cognition:** Thinking patterns, beliefs about self and others
- **Subjective experience:** Personal interpretation of reality
- **Psychological mechanisms:** How we process experiences differs across individuals

C. Applications

- **Kelly's Personal Construct Theory:** People interpret life using mental "constructs" or frameworks.
- **Bandura's Social Learning Theory:** Observational learning and self-efficacy influence personality.

Example:

- Two students face a failed exam:
 - One thinks, "I'm not smart" → may feel hopeless (negative cognitive pattern).
 - Another thinks, "I'll study differently next time" → proactive and confident (positive cognitive pattern).

Explanation (Plain English):

This perspective says personality is not just traits or biology—it's how you **think and experience life**. How you interpret events, your beliefs, and conscious choices shape how you behave and feel.

Tip:

- Remember: **Personality = thoughts + experiences**.
- Focus on **mental frameworks and perception**.

6. Explain the social and cultural perspective.

Answer:

A. Core Idea

Personality is influenced not just by internal traits or biology, but by **social and cultural context**.

B. Key Concepts

- **Cultural norms:** Rules of behavior, expectations in society
- **Social roles:** Behavior patterns influenced by relationships and society

- **Cross-cultural differences:** Personality varies in collectivist vs individualist cultures

Example:

- Collectivist culture → group harmony valued → agreeable personality develops
- Individualist culture → personal achievement valued → assertive, independent personality develops

C. Key Theorists

- **Hofstede:** Cultural dimensions affecting behavior (e.g., individualism vs collectivism)
- **Triandis:** Influence of social structures on personality

Explanation (Plain English):

This perspective says **you are who society and culture help shape you to be**. Traits exist, but social norms, expectations, and culture **mold how they express**.

Tip:

- Remember: Personality = trait + social environment.
 - Think of culture as the **software updates** for your personality.
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7. Explain the adjustment perspective.

Answer:

A. Core Idea

Personality plays a role in **coping, adapting, and adjusting** to life events.

Good adjustment = healthy coping; poor adjustment = psychological/physical problems.

B. Applications

- **Stress and coping:** Personality affects response to stress

- **Health psychology:** Links between personality and health outcomes
 - Heart disease, sleep patterns, diet, exercise, longevity

C. Example

- Optimistic person → handles failure better → less stress → healthier
- Pessimistic person → avoids challenges → higher risk of depression → poor physical health

Explanation (Plain English):

Adjustment perspective emphasizes the **practical side of personality**. It's not just traits or thoughts—it's about **how you navigate life successfully**, and how that affects your health and well-being.

Tip:

- Remember: Adjustment = **coping + health outcomes**.
- Personality isn't only about who you are; it's about **how you function in real life**.

✓ Summary Table – Six Perspectives at a Glance

Perspective	Focus	Example	Key Theorists
Dispositional	Traits, differences	Honest, kind, aggressive	Allport, Cattell, Murray
Biological	Genes, physiology, evolution	Twin similarities, cortisol levels	Freud, Sheldon, Erikson
Intrapsychic	Unconscious conflicts	Clinginess due to childhood fear	Freud, Jung, Horney
Cognitive/Experiential	Thoughts, beliefs, experiences	Reaction to exam failure	Kelly, Bandura
Social/Cultural	Culture and social norms	Collectivist vs individualist behavior	Hofstede, Triandis
Adjustment	Coping and adaptation	Stress handling, health outcomes	Lazarus, Carver

Cheat Sheet

1. Six Perspectives of Personality

Perspective	Focus / Keywords	Key Question	Example	Tip / Mnemonic
Dispositional	Traits, individual differences, stable patterns	How do people differ?	Honest vs aggressive	Mnemonic: D = "Differences in traits"
Biological	Genes, hormones, physiology, evolution	How do biology & genetics shape personality?	Twins → similar traits; morning vs night person	B = Body / Biology
Intrapsychic	Unconscious, conflicts, drives	How do unconscious conflicts shape behavior?	Fear of abandonment → clinginess	I = Inside mind
Cognitive / Experiential	Thoughts, beliefs, perceptions, experiences	How do thinking patterns shape personality?	Interprets failure positively vs negatively	C = Conscious thinking
Social / Cultural	Society, norms, culture	How does culture shape personality?	Collectivist culture → agreeableness	S = Society
Adjustment	Coping, adaptation, health	How does personality affect coping & health?	Optimist → handles stress → healthier	A = Adaptation

2. Dispositional Perspective – Key Terms

Term	Definition	Example	Memory Hook
Trait	Stable mental structure guiding behavior	Honest across work & home	"Trait = Habit of mind"

Term	Definition	Example	Memory Hook
Disposition	Inborn tendency to behave a certain way	Calm person remains calm under stress	"Disposition = default setting"
Cardinal Trait	Dominant, rare trait shaping entire personality	Mother Teresa → compassion	Cardinal = "Chief / Dominant"
Central Trait	Core traits of personality	Friendly, honest, anxious	Central = "Main pillars"
Secondary Trait	Situational or minor traits	Nervous before exams	Secondary = "Minor / Occasional"
Proprium	The self; unifying concept of personality	Goals, values, self-identity	Proprium = "Proper self"
Measurement Tools	16PF, TAT, questionnaires	Cattell's 16PF test	Remember: Qualitative & Quantitative

Tip: Language, Statistical & Theoretical approaches help identify traits.

3. Biological Perspective – Key Terms

Term	Definition	Example	Tip / Mnemonic
Genetics	Influence of DNA on personality	Identical twins → similar traits	Twin = "Genes matter"
Psychophysiology	Body systems & personality	High cortisol → anxious	Think "Body-brain connection"
Evolution	Traits shaped for survival	Fear → survival advantage	"E = Endurance / Survival"
Sheldon's Somatotypes	Body type → personality	Mesomorph → assertive	Endomorph = relaxed, Ectomorph = shy
Freud	Sex & aggression as biological drives	Oral/Anal/Phallic/Genital stages	Biology + Instincts = BFI (Basic Freudian Instincts)
Erikson	Biology + culture influence	Gender differences shaped socially	Remember: "Bio + Social"

Tip: Think **Body = hardware, Traits = software.**

4. Intrapsychic Perspective – Key Terms

Term	Definition	Example	Mnemonic / Tip
Id	Primitive instincts, pleasure principle	"I want cake now"	I = Instinct
Ego	Rational, reality principle	Eats small piece of cake	E = Executive / Planner
Superego	Moral, conscience	Doesn't eat cake → moral reason	S = Super-moral
Conscious	Thoughts we know	Current thoughts	"Conscious = aware"
Preconscious	Thoughts accessible if needed	Memories of yesterday	"Pre = almost conscious"
Unconscious	Hidden, powerful influence	Childhood fears shaping behavior	"Unseen iceberg"
Defense Mechanisms	Ego strategies to reduce anxiety	Repression, Projection, Sublimation	Remember: RPD = Reduce Pressure Daily
Psychosexual Stages	Oral, Anal, Phallic, Latency, Genital	Oral fixation → smoking	"OAPLG = Our Awesome Personality Life Guide"
Jung's Archetypes	Universal inherited symbols	Persona, Shadow, Anima/Animus, Self	Think: "PJAS = Personality Journey Archetypes Story"
Karen Horney	Basic anxiety & neurosis	Child insecure → adult hostility	Focus: Security > Biology

5. Cognitive / Experiential Perspective – Key Terms

Term	Definition	Example	Tip / Mnemonic
Cognition	Thoughts, beliefs, perceptions	"I can't do this" vs "I can try differently"	"C = Conscious thinking"
Subjective Experience	Personal interpretation of	Optimist sees failure as learning	"Subjective = self lens"

Term	Definition	Example	Tip / Mnemonic
	events		
Personal Construct (Kelly)	Mental framework for interpreting life	Friend = loyal or untrustworthy	"Construct your view"
Self-Efficacy (Bandura)	Belief in ability to succeed	Believes can pass exam → tries harder	SE = "Success Expectation"

Tip: Cognitive = how you **think, interpret, and react**.

6. Social / Cultural Perspective – Key Terms

Term	Definition	Example	Tip / Mnemonic
Culture	Shared values, norms, expectations	Collectivist → group harmony	C = Customs
Social Roles	Behavior shaped by society	Teacher → authoritative; Parent → caring	"Roles = Rules by society"
Cross-Cultural Differences	Personality varies by culture	Assertive in individualist, not collectivist	"CCD = Cultural Character Differences"
Theorists	Hofstede, Triandis	Power distance, individualism	Remember: "Social lens matters"

Tip: Personality = trait + social environment.

7. Adjustment Perspective – Key Terms

Term	Definition	Example	Tip / Mnemonic
Adjustment	Ability to cope, adapt, and function in daily life	Optimist handles stress better	A = Adaptation
Coping Mechanisms	Strategies to manage stress	Problem-solving, relaxation, humor	"Cope to cope"

Term	Definition	Example	Tip / Mnemonic
Health Link	Personality affects physical & mental health	Optimist → better sleep, lower heart disease risk	Remember: Personality = Lifestyle Influence

8. Useful Memory Hooks & Mnemonics

1. **Six Perspectives** → **D-BI-C-SA**

Dispositional, **B**iological, **I**ntrapsychic, **C**ognitive, **S**ocial, **A** Adjustment

2. **Allport's Trait Importance** → **Cardinal > Central > Secondary**

"Chief pillars, main pillars, minor bricks"

3. **Freud's Iceberg** → Conscious = tip, Preconscious = just below, Unconscious = huge hidden mass

4. **Defense Mechanisms** → **RPD**

Repression, **P**rojection, **D**isplacement (core ones)

5. **Psychosexual Stages** → **OAPLG** = Oral, Anal, Phallic, Latency, Genital